DEAR

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I am inhabited by a cry.
Nightly it flaps out
Looking, with its hooks, for something to love.

I am terrified by this dark thing
That sleeps in me;
All day I feel its soft, feathery turnings, its malignity.

— Elm, Sylvia Plath

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THE GAME

I am no saint,
and the darkness within my heart
bothers me heavily.

Yet the darkness I carry
is no match
for the storms of this world.

When the world shows
its teeth,
my softness becomes my shame.

Life is a game
and I do not have
the claws to play.

36TH OF JULY

On the 36th of July,
the streets overflowed with voices—
rising, trembling, breaking into laughter,
a strange and beautiful sound,
like waves crashing against the shore
after too long a silence.

They laughed—
a sound like monsoon rain,
smashing the dust from prison walls.

They wept—
as if drowning a ghost,
something that had choked their sky
for too many midnights.

(What is a dictator but a ghost
who mistakes fear for worship?)

PARALLEL UNIVERSE

Dear,

In another world,
I do not suffer from insomnia.
I do not write poetry—
or whatever this is—
full of sadness.

I have you as my wife.
We have children—
lots of them.
And they fill the rooms
with fight and light.

In another world,
I do not repeat my mistakes.
I do not become a loser.
They do not know me as the strange, lazy man
with no job, no aim.
But as an ordinary man,
the kind who goes to office at 8 AM
and works until 5 PM.

YOUR JEALOUSY

Among all other things,
I love your jealousy the most.
When we walk side by side,
your eyes lock onto mine—
are they watching another woman?
Even if it's just toward a cat stretching in the sun.
What's so fascinating over there? You ask,
eyes narrowed like a detective in a crime thriller.

The way you glare if a woman dares
to glance in my direction—
your hand grips mine a little tighter,
your shoulders stiffening,
your lips pressing into a thin line,
as if sending her a message—
This man belongs to me.

The way you scroll through my posts,
pausing—who liked them? Who commented?
And when a woman's name appears,
you hiss, *Who is she?*
I smile, amused, as I reply,
I really don't know who Angel Priya is.
Your eyes narrow, suspicion thick as honey.